An hour later he walked into Nott Cott, where he hadn't been since Meg first moved in. He looked piping hot.

It was early evening. I offered him a drink, asked about his family.

Everyone good.

He didn't ask about mine. He just went all in. Chips to the center of the table.

Meg's difficult, he said.

Oh, really?

She's rude. She's abrasive. She's alienated half the staff.

Not the first time he'd parroted the press narrative. Duchess Difficult, all that bullshit. Rumors, lies from his team, tabloid rubbish, and I told him so—again. Told him I expected better from my older brother. I was shocked to see that this actually pissed him off. Had he come here expecting something different? Did he think I'd agree that my bride was a monster?

I told him to step back, take a breath, really ask himself: Wasn't Meg his sister-in-law? Wouldn't this institution be toxic for any newcomer? Worst-case scenario, if his sister-in-law was having trouble adjusting to a new office, a new family, a new country, a new culture, couldn't he see his way clear to cutting her some slack? *Couldn't you just be there for her? Help her?*

He had no interest in a debate. He'd come to lay down the law. He wanted me to agree that Meg was wrong and then agree to do something about it.

Like what? Scold her? Fire her? Divorce her? I didn't know. But Willy didn't know either, he wasn't rational. Every time I tried to slow him down, point out the illogic of what he was saying, he got louder. We were soon talking over each other, both of us shouting.

Among all the different, riotous emotions coursing through my brother that afternoon, one really jumped out at me. He seemed *aggrieved*. He seemed put upon that I wasn't meekly obeying him, that I was being so impertinent as to deny him, or defy him, to refute his knowledge, which came from his trusted aides. There was a script here and I had the audacity not to be following it. He was in full Heir mode, and couldn't fathom why I wasn't dutifully playing the role of the Spare.

I was sitting on the sofa, he was standing over me. I remember saying: *You need to hear me out, Willy.*

He wouldn't. He simply would not listen.